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LXX AND MT: ASPECTS OF RELATIONSHIP

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The accentuation of MT is not always consistent with its vowelling. This is clearly seen in Deut 5:14, in the list of those who must not work on the Sabbath. Such lists are usually divided by the accents into groups of two or three items. If these groups form separate verses, as they often do (cf. passages like Neh 10:3-8), a pausal form stands at the end of each group, as in Lev 14:54-56. If the groups stand within a verse, each group does not end in a pausal form, as *ומצרים* in Gen 10:6 (although some may). In Deut 5:14, the vowelling of the pausal forms *ובתך*, *ואמך*, *בהמך*, reflects the first method of presentation, while the accentuation, which treats the whole list as one part of one half of the verse, requires the second. This clearly shows that the reading tradition represented in MT had a history long enough to permit the development of inconsistencies, whether they arose through internal change or through the introduction of material from more than one source.

In a number of such cases, the vowelling suggests the *Vorlage* of the Greek translation. In Ps 10:15, the *qames* on the conjunction in *וְשַׁע וְרַע* shows that the two words were once taken as a single unit, as in the Greek *τοῦ ἀμαρτωλοῦ καὶ πονηροῦ* (so also Jerome). For the accentuation, however, *וְשַׁע* ends the first clause, and so is marked with *atnah* while *וְרַע* begins the second. Ps 3:9 shows a case involving a slight textual difference. In the Hebrew, *ברכתך* is the only example in eight possible cases¹ of a

¹The other cases are Ps 21:3; 32:4; 62:5; 66:4; 76:10; 82:2; 89:5.

reflect an ancient variant where no change of wording is involved, it must be possible for them to do so even where a change of wording did occur. Goshen-Gottstein believes it unlikely that any variant found in a mediaeval MS derives from texts contemporary with the translation into Greek,⁸ but the features of interest here are part of the standard tradition, not variants. It seems, therefore, worthwhile to investigate the possibility of relationship between such features and the text reflected in the Greek translation.

It is certainly true that for most of the period from this translation up to the final completion of MT, the written biblical text contained only the letters of the "consonantal" text. However the form in which this text functioned in the community, as in the liturgy, in teaching, or in legal discussion, was wholly, or at least primarily, oral.

The transmission of all written language is in origin oral, because the reader must be taught the relation of the written symbols to the language he speaks. Where the writing system does not represent all the sounds of the language, and also where the language to be read differs from that spoken, the influence of oral teaching — that is, the reliance on the teacher's identification of the spoken word corresponding to any group of letters — must be greatly increased. Finally, in a situation in which, as with the Hebrew Bible, the text to be read is of limited extent, in constant use, and of great importance to the community, one must suppose the effect of oral teaching to be particularly strong, and likely to persist. Natural resistance to change, and the relatively small size of any one community, makes it likely that all the readers in each community would see the same words in the text, so that different readers would differ no more in their reading than they would when using the same words in the vernacular. *A priori*, then, it can be said that a stable community with a stable text will have a stable reading tradition.⁹

In his study of the manuscript evidence (note 8) Goshen-Gottstein sees the period of "stabilization" of the text of the Hebrew Bible as beginning in the first century BC, and ending with the absolute dominance of the masoretic text type about 100 AD. This period is characterized by an increasing tendency for all texts to conform to the masoretic model. If so, this model must have been in existence

⁸See "Hebrew Biblical Manuscripts," *Biblica* 48 (1967) 243-90, particularly p. 285-86.

⁹"Stable" here is not intended to mean "unchanging" but "not suffering significant change due to strong external influence or to carelessness within the community."

conformity with it.¹³ The Greek translation is also adapted in this MS to reflect, in the way perfected in much greater detail by Aquila, the minor details of the Hebrew text considered significant for its interpretation. This shows that, by the mid first century AD the Hebrew text of the Prophets was believed to be unchanging, so that such minor details could serve as a basis for interpretation.

The *qere/ketiv* tradition of MT provides further evidence, less definite, but still worth consideration. In many examples it appears that the *ketiv* results from scribal error, while the *qere* represents the original reading tradition, naturally unaffected by a fault in the transmission of the written text.¹⁴ In other cases the *ketiv* certainly represents a reading acceptable at some time or in some place, but superseded by the *qere*, either through preference of an alternative tradition, or through a change made by some scholarly group.¹⁵ The most common example of this type is the use of a surrogate for the tetragrammeton. The general use of κύριος to represent the tetragrammeton in Greek, rather than a transliteration, as used for other names, must surely reflect the use of this surrogate.¹⁶ The extreme care in the treatment of divine names shown in some Qumran MSS must be a later development of the original usage.¹⁷ If this argument is correct, it shows that the Hebrew text was regarded as unchangeable (whatever the actual facts) from a very early date, and that at least some features of the reading tradition originated at that early time.

The suggestion of a stable reading tradition may seem to be contradicted by the evidence of mediaeval MSS, which show wide differences in vocalization. These differences are, however, mainly

¹³See D. Barthélemy, *Devanciers*. A vowel pattern variant from MT was retained in one case (p. 198, f), but was corrected in four (p. 197, 2i). The punctuation shown in this MS must be Jewish in origin, and resembles the marking of punctuation by the pausal forms in MT (See *JSJ* 7 [1976] 195-97). Punctuation is not part of the written Greek tradition, but the careful and consistent punctuation of this and some other early Greek MSS presumably represents a reading tradition familiar to the copyist, and the nature of this MS makes it possible that in this case that tradition was in Hebrew.

¹⁴This is probable for many examples of category 4 of *qere/ketiv* in I. Yeivin, *Introduction to the Tiberian Masorah* (Missoula, 1980) #101.

¹⁵This must be generally true where the *ketiv* shows a dialectal form, a coarse expression, or a divine name, for which the *qere* presents the standard form, a euphemism, or a surrogate. See categories 1, 3, and 6, in Yeivin, *Introduction* #98, 100, 103.

¹⁶Its representation in Hebrew letters in some Greek MSS, as 848, 943, is presumably a way of distinguishing sacred from profane, to promote proper reverence, or the needs of interpretation, as was later done in the Masorah for words which might be used in both spheres.

¹⁷Examples are the use of the old Hebrew script in 11QPs^a, and the four dots replacing the tetragrammeton in 1QS 8:14, 4Q175 1, 19.

form of this suffix with a final vowel, represented a pronunciation archaic in Palestine in the masoretic period.²³ Thus although the evidence shows that, as a general rule, there was no effective resistance to the influence of natural phonological change on the biblical reading tradition, such change was resisted in particular cases. Due to such resistance, the 2ms pronominal suffix has been preserved in MT in a historically earlier form than the vulgarized form represented in the fragments of the second column of the Hexapla.

The evidence so far considered is perfectly consistent with the view that a standard reading tradition, corresponding to the standard text which developed into MT, was transmitted along with that text from at least 100 BC. It is reasonable to assume that where the letters of a text differed from this standard in some passages, the understanding of that text might also differ in passages where the letters were the same. This is the situation found in the Greek translation, which reflects not only variants from the letters of MT, but also cases where the same letters were understood as different words, and cases where the same words were differently associated in phrases and clauses. Too little attention has been paid to such "vocalization variants" to allow any more than a superficial estimation of the relationship of the understanding of the text in the Greek translation to the MT reading tradition, although it seems likely that the number of such variants is generally overestimated.²⁴

Under the argument above, it must be assumed that the Greek translation was based on some form of Hebrew reading tradition, for any competent or acceptable translator must have been familiar with the text in a community setting, and hence familiar with a reading tradition. The reflection of Jewish interpretations in the translation, and the distinction, in the transcription of names, of gutturals not distinguished in the Hebrew script, would seem to support this.²⁵ The question of whether the Greek translation, even in individual books, derives from any form of cohesive textual tradition supported by its

²³See the study of this phenomenon in Z. Ben Hayyim, *Studies in the Traditions of the Hebrew Language* (Madrid, 1954) chap. I.

²⁴The only detailed listing known to me is that given by L. C. Allen in *The Greek Chronicles* part II (VTSup 27; Leiden, 1974) 67.

²⁵For a study of the Greek transcriptions of *h/kh*, see J. W. Wevers "Heth in Classical Hebrew," *Essays on the Ancient Semitic World* (ed. J. W. Wevers and D. B. Redford; Toronto, 1970) 101-12, and now J. Blau "On Polyphony in Biblical Hebrew," *Israel Academy of Sciences and Humanities* (Proceedings VI.2, 1982), where transcriptions of */gh* are also treated, and conclusions significant for the history of the Greek translation are drawn (15.1).

13:17 שׁ was present, so that the development of *nesiga* in נאכל was prevented. The bearers of the reading tradition became convinced, in these cases, that both the written text they had followed, and the reading tradition based on it, were wrong. Consequently the word in question was added to, or expunged from, both. Typically, no change was made in the other words in the context in any of these cases, so that the anomalous vowel or stress pattern remained.²⁸

Such changes cannot be dated, beyond the statement that they occurred after the reading tradition was so firmly fixed that the vowelling would not be automatically adjusted to the new situation. The form of the 2ms pronominal suffix in the fragments of the second column of the Hexapla suggests that the individual vowels were fixed in the tradition by Origen's time.²⁹ Any vowel might undergo phonological change, but it would not be removed or replaced. There is no evidence from before the time of Origen. It is, therefore, possible that the variant which was suppressed in the cases considered above had been circulating since the time when the Greek translation was made.

Despite this possibility, it seems likely that these changes are examples of the further standardization of the biblical tradition which took place after 100 AD.³⁰ If so, they throw a welcome light on a period for which there is no textual evidence. The differences between the Tiberian and Babylonian traditions show clearly that, during this period, the reading tradition was not transmitted by a single group in a single form, all variations from which are vulgarizations or errors. The fact that Ps 10:15 and other passages clearly reflect two different ways of understanding the letters of the

²⁸Mordecai Breuer has arrived at similar conclusions in his discussion of *ketiv* and *te'im* in *Leshonenu* 45 (1980-81) 260-66, where he deals with inconsistencies similar to those treated here. These cases differ from the *ketiv* and *qere* to which he compares them, in that in *qere/ketiv* situations, the reading tradition was maintained independent of the written text, while in these cases it was not (save for the fact that, as Breuer also notes on p. 262, the vowelling was not changed to fit changed wording). These cases are, in fact, a corollary of the *qere/ketiv* phenomenon. In *qerē welā ketiv* and *ketiv welā qerē*, the reading tradition correctly includes (or omits) a word absent (or present) in the written text. It stands to reason that in some cases of such variation, the written tradition must have been judged correct, and the reading tradition changed accordingly.

²⁹Notes on vowels and accents belong to the latest stages of the Masorah because written signs for these features were not in use in earlier periods. Evidence of interest in vowel patterns at a much earlier date is found, e.g. in *M. Abod. Zar.* 2:5, in *Berēšit Rabbah* 50:3, where the verb in the interpretation בא ערבה של סדם must reflect the definite article in בְּעֶרְבָּ (Gen 19:1), and in the *al tiqrē* formula, which assumes a standard reading tradition, to be changed for purposes of hermeneutics.

³⁰See Goshen-Gottstein, *Biblica* 48 (1967) 288 n.2.

The origin of variants can, however, only be discussed in terms of possibilities. The main purpose of this paper is not to claim an early origin for the three cases discussed, but to show that such an origin is possible. When the development of the Hebrew biblical text is considered, the existence of a stable reading tradition from an early date must be taken into account. Some further definition of "stable" will be possible when the work on the Babylonian tradition going forward in Spain and in Israel is fully published, so we can know what features were firmly established in the tradition before the Tiberian and Babylonian streams separated. Better definition of the "early date" requires more detailed study of the "vocalization variants," including such features as difference in clause boundaries, reflected in the various forms of the Greek translation. It is to be hoped that this, too, will soon become available.